

Marktpotenzial einer AI-nativen Software für Nebenkostenabrechnungen

Deutschland | SaaS-Markt, Wettbewerb und Go-to-Market

INVESTMENT THESIS

**Large market, painful annual workflow,
but trust and distribution decide the winner.**

Base TAM: EUR 600m p.a. | Base SAM: EUR 174m p.a. | 5-year base SOM: EUR 6m ARR

A strong market - with a narrow winning condition

Germany combines a large rental base, annual regulatory work and fragmented private ownership. The opportunity is real, but AI alone is not the moat: trust, traceability and distribution are.

25.0m rental units	16.1m private-landlord units	EUR 600m base TAM / year
Underlying recurring workflow [1]	64.4% of rental stock [1]	25m x EUR 24 annual ARPU

Why now

- Annual billing is mandatory when operating-cost advances are agreed; delivery is due within 12 months after the period ends. [2]
- CO2 cost splitting and consumption-information duties add rules, data fields and error risk. [3][4]
- Incumbents already validate willingness to pay and offer OCR or AI document capture. [5][6][7]

The winning product

- Document-to-draft in minutes, not a form that merely digitizes manual entry.
- Deterministic calculation engine after AI extraction; every euro links back to a source document.
- Contract-aware treatment of allocation keys, vacancies and tenant changes, with an explicit approval step.

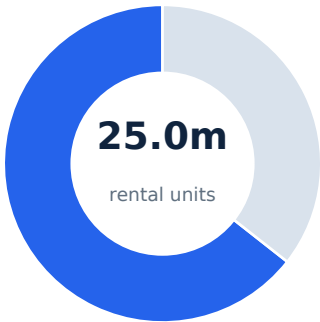
Bottom line

GO - with milestones. A focused product can plausibly reach EUR 6m ARR at 250,000 units within five years, equal to only 3.5% of the base SAM units. The investment case should be gated by proof of calculation accuracy, time saved and a repeatable channel - not by top-down market size alone.

Confidence: high on market volume and legal recurrence; medium on attainable ARPU; low-to-medium on adoption speed until pilot conversion is observed.

The market is large, recurring and unusually fragmented

The 2022 Census-based IW analysis counts 25.0m rental units. Private landlords supply 16.1m units and 5.5m households act as landlords - a broad buyer base with limited standardization. [1]



Private landlords: 16.1m (64.4%)

Other providers: 8.9m (35.6%)

5.5m private landlord households

= fragmented buyer base and channel opportunity

Demand driver	What creates work	Product implication
Annual cycle	Billing recurs every year for advance payments; deadlines reset annually. [2]	High retention potential once property data and history are stored.
Rule density	Allocation keys, consumption shares, CO2 split, tenant changes and document access.	Rules engine and evidence graph matter more than a generic chatbot.
Fragmentation	Private landlords hold 64.4% of rentals; many manage alongside another occupation. [1]	Simple onboarding and partner distribution outperform enterprise-style implementation.
Data digitization	Invoices, meters and contracts increasingly arrive digitally, but formats remain heterogeneous.	AI extraction is useful; confidence scoring and human review are mandatory.

Structural insight

The same fragmentation that makes sales expensive also creates the product opening. Large ERP suites are often too broad for a landlord with 2-30 units; pure templates lack automation and auditability. A focused billing product can enter through a painful annual job and later expand into rent, documents and tenant communication.

Base case: EUR 174m serviceable annual software spend

All values are recurring software revenue, not the operating-cost money flowing through the system. The model uses annual revenue per billed unit (ARPU) and explicitly separates observed data from assumptions.



Layer	Units	ARPU	Annual value	Logic
TAM	25.0m	EUR 24	EUR 600m	All rental units in Germany [1]
SAM - base	7.2m	EUR 24	EUR 174m	45% of 16.1m private units digitally reachable; assumption
SOM - year 5	0.25m	EUR 24	EUR 6m ARR	3.5% of base SAM units; direct + channel

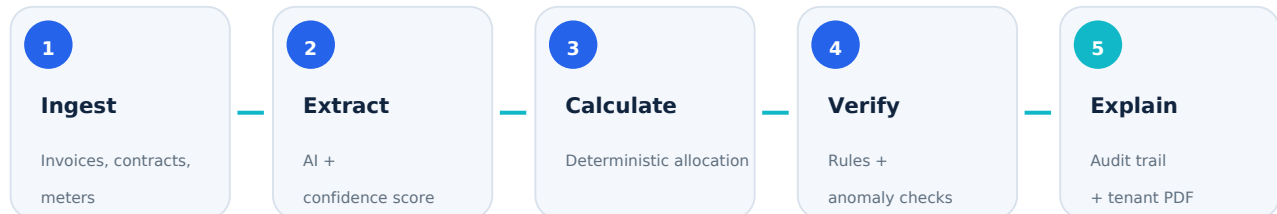
Sensitivity - serviceable market

Scenario	Reachable share	Units	ARPU / year	SAM
Low	35%	5.6m	EUR 18	EUR 101m
Base	45%	7.2m	EUR 24	EUR 174m
High	55%	8.9m	EUR 30	EUR 266m

Interpretation: the market remains material even under the low case. The decisive uncertainty is not the number of rental units; it is the percentage of owners willing to switch from spreadsheets, tax advisers or bundled property software to a focused workflow.

The wedge is not 'AI'; it is a defensible, explainable bill

A credible system combines probabilistic document understanding with deterministic money movement. This architecture reduces hallucination risk and makes every number reviewable.



AI reads ambiguity. The ledger decides money. A human approves release.

Customer	Core pain	Must-have outcome	Buying trigger
Private landlord 2-30 units	Seasonal paperwork; changing tenants; uncertainty about allocation.	Upload documents, review exceptions, send a transparent PDF.	First multi-unit property; inherited portfolio; bad spreadsheet experience.
Professional manager 50-1,000 units	Batch throughput, staff cost, inconsistent quality, tenant questions.	Bulk ingestion, approval queues, roles, exports and audit logs.	Peak-season backlog; staff shortage; migration from legacy tools.
Partner / platform	Needs billing capability without building a full rules engine.	API or white-label module with clear liability boundary.	Product expansion, retention or cross-sell into existing customer base.

Minimum trustworthy product

- Invoice and contract extraction with field-level confidence.
- Allocation keys: area, persons, units, consumption, time.
- Move-in/out, vacancy and mid-period changes.
- Versioned rule checks for BGB, BetrKV, HeizkostenV and CO2 split.
- Source-linked calculation graph and anomaly detection.
- Tenant-ready PDF, evidence room and export/API.

Willingness to pay is proven; full automation is not yet owned

Public product pages show established digital billing and document recognition. The whitespace is a specialized, source-linked workflow that handles ambiguity and produces an audit-ready explanation. Public features may not reflect every capability.

Provider / model	Public price signal	Relevant public capability	Strategic read
objego	EUR 0.95 / unit / month incl. VAT for Nebenkosten module [5]	Digital compliant bill, data checks, automatic invoice reading, self-read heating.	Sharp low-price benchmark; strong private-landlord fit; owned by ista ecosystem.
immocloud	EUR 9.99 / month up to 5; EUR 39.99 / month up to 50, net [6]	Broad management suite with billing, meter management, DATEV and AI receipt capture.	Integrated suite sets a high feature bar; unit economics improve with portfolio size.
Vermieten Plus	EUR 9.90 / month incl. 1 unit + EUR 0.99 per added unit [7]	Billing assistant, OCR upload, finance and ImmoScout24 distribution.	Distribution moat and cross-sell; broader landlord workflow rather than billing-only.
Spreadsheets / service	Low software fee or high per-case service fee	Maximum flexibility or full delegation.	Main substitute. Product must beat spreadsheet control and adviser trust.

Recommended position

Promise	From documents to a reviewable draft in under 45 minutes per building.
Proof	Every amount links to invoice, contract clause, allocation key and formula.
Boundary	The system proposes and checks; the owner or manager explicitly approves.
Moat	A growing corpus of corrected documents, allocation mappings and exception patterns - not a thin LLM wrapper.

Win a narrow segment, then let partners multiply units

Direct acquisition teaches the workflow; partners improve economics. A five-year base SOM of 250,000 units needs both motions.

75k direct units	125k channel units	50k embedded units
Landlords and small managers	Associations, advisers, managers	API / white-label partners

Phase	Ideal customer	Motion	Success gate
1. Beachhead	Self-managing owners with 2-30 units and at least one tenant change.	SEO on specific billing cases; sample audit report; paid founder-led onboarding.	Paid conversion >25%; median first bill <45 min.
2. Workflow scale	Managers with 50-1,000 units.	Portfolio migration, roles, batch review, DATEV/ERP export; annual contracts.	Gross retention >90%; support <20 min per 100 units/month.
3. Distribution	Tax advisers, owner associations, metering firms, property platforms.	Referral revenue share, co-branded output, API and white-label packaging.	Partner CAC payback <12 months; >1,000 active units/partner.

Five-year SOM scenarios

Scenario	Units	Share of base SAM	ARPU	ARR
Low	50,000	0.7%	EUR 20	EUR 1.0m
Base	250,000	3.5%	EUR 24	EUR 6.0m
High	600,000	8.3%	EUR 28	EUR 16.8m

Price for saved risk and time - not for OCR tokens

Public benchmarks imply roughly EUR 10-24 per unit-year at portfolio scale, with higher minimum fees for small portfolios. [5][6][7] A hybrid minimum fee plus per-unit price protects support economics.

Plan	Illustrative price	Target	Rationale
Starter	EUR 119 / year up to 5 units	Private landlords	Simple decision; equivalent to EUR 24/unit at five units.
Growth	EUR 2.00 / unit / month EUR 29 minimum	6-100 units	Scales with volume; includes collaboration and recurring data store.
Pro / API	EUR 1.00-1.75 / unit / month annual minimum	Managers and partners	Volume discount; onboarding, SLA and integrations priced separately.

Illustrative unit-economic targets

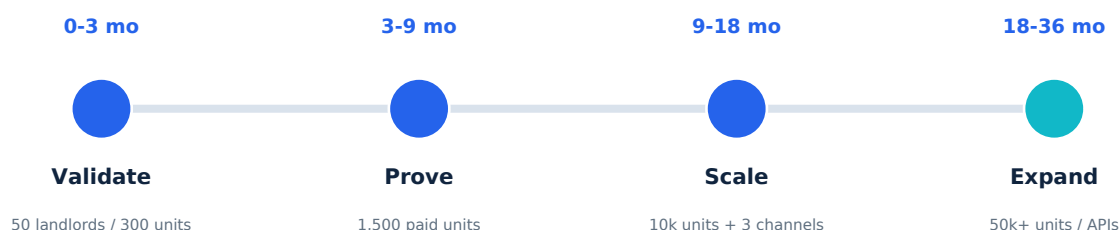
85%+ gross margin	<12 mo CAC payback	>90% gross retention
After OCR/LLM, storage and support	Direct and partner blended target	Measured on annual recurring revenue

Risk register

Risk	Impact / likelihood	Mitigation
Incorrect allocation or legal interpretation	High / medium	Deterministic engine, legal review, versioned rules, confidence thresholds, explicit approval and insurance.
Incumbent bundles copy features	High / high	Own the audit trail, exception data and partner API; integrate with suites rather than replace all workflows.
Seasonal usage and churn	Medium / high	Annual contracts, persistent property ledger, monthly document inbox and adjacent workflows.
Sensitive tenant and financial data	High / medium	EU hosting, data minimization, encryption, access logs, deletion controls and DPAs.

Prove trust and throughput before scaling acquisition

The fastest path to de-risking is a controlled billing season with real documents, edge cases and post-approval error measurement.



Pilot metric	Go threshold	Why it matters
Document field accuracy	>95% on required fields	Determines reviewer effort and financial risk.
Straight-through extraction	>80% of standard invoices	Shows AI creates real throughput, not merely a demo.
Median completion time	<45 minutes / building	Supports clear ROI versus manual workflows.
Post-approval financial corrections	<1% of issued bills	Core trust and liability signal.
Paid conversion	>25% of completed pilots	Validates willingness to pay, not just curiosity.
Support load	<20 min / 100 units / month	Protects an 85%+ gross-margin model.

GO

Proceed with a focused MVP and paid pilot.

The market is large enough under conservative assumptions. Do not fund broad property-management scope until the core calculation workflow meets the accuracy, time and conversion gates above.

STOP / PIVOT

If pilots need expert rework on >5% of cases or customers will not pay at least EUR 100-150 per small portfolio per year, shift toward a professional co-pilot/API for managers rather than a self-serve landlord product.

Method, assumptions and sources

Market estimates are directional and designed for startup planning. Observed facts are cited; all reach, pricing and share assumptions are shown explicitly so the model can be replaced with pilot evidence.

Item	Treatment
TAM	25.0m German rental units x EUR 24 annual software revenue per unit.
SAM	16.1m privately supplied units x 45% digitally reachable x EUR 24. The 45% factor is a planning assumption, not an official statistic.
SOM	250,000 active paid units in year 5 x EUR 24. This equals 3.5% of base SAM units and assumes partner distribution.
Revenue scope	Recurring software only; excludes payment float, pass-through operating costs, consulting and postage.
Price comparison	Public list prices observed on 21 Sep 2026; taxes and included features differ, so comparisons are directional.

Sources

[1] Institut der deutschen Wirtschaft / Haus & Grund (2025), Private Vermieter in Deutschland. 25.0m rental units, 16.1m private-landlord units, 64.4% share and 5.5m landlord households.
<https://www.iwkoeln.de/studien/christian-oberst-pekka-sagner-michael-voigtlaender-private-vermieter-in-deutschland.html>

[2] Bundesministerium der Justiz, BGB § 556. Annual billing, 12-month deadline and electronic document access.
https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/bgb/_556.html

[3] Bundesministerium der Justiz, CO2KostAufG § 5. Allocation of CO2 costs for residential buildings.
https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/co2kostaufg/_5.html

[4] Bundesministerium der Justiz, HeizkostenV §§ 5, 6a, 7. Remote-readability, monthly information and 50-70% consumption allocation. <https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/heizkostenv/>

[5] objego price and feature page. EUR 0.95 per rental unit/month incl. VAT for the Nebenkosten module; invoice import and checks.
<https://www.objego.de/preise/>

[6] immocloud tariff page. Public tier prices and included AI receipt capture, billing, meters and DATEV.
<https://www.immocloud.de/tarife/>

[7] ImmoScout24 VermietenPlus. EUR 9.90/month incl. one unit plus EUR 0.99/month per additional unit; OCR and billing assistant.
<https://www.immobilienscout24.de/anbieten/private-anbieter/lp/vermietetde.html>

Limitations

No audited market-revenue data for the narrow software category was identified. The market model therefore triangulates official housing counts with current public SaaS prices. Competitive features are based on public product pages and may omit non-public capabilities. Regulatory summaries are not legal advice.